



VIKRAMSINHRAJE JADHAVRAO (LEFT), RAJA OF MALEGAON BUDRUK, IS A BUILDER IN PUNE WHO HELPS SLUM-DWELLERS. HIS ANCESTOR WAS THE MARATHA GENERAL DHANAJI WHO TERRORISED AURANGZEB.



converting to Islam. Ranojirao is a farmer in his ancestral village of Kapshi near Kolhapur; his living room boasts of 103 hunting trophies.

Like Ranojirao, Dilip Singh Himmat Bahadur Chavan is also a farmer in Nigwe near Kolhapur. His ancestor Vithoji earned the title of Himmat Bahadur from Shivaji's son Raja Ram for his bravery against the Mughals. He says, "History has not given generals like Santaji Ghorpade, Dhanaji Jadhav and Vithoji their true place. They had terrorised Aurangzeb and had almost captured him once." The trio once entered Aurangzeb's camp, plundered it and cut off the penants at its gate.

Vikramsinhraje Jadhavrao, the Raja of Malegaon Budruk near Baramati and a descendant of Dhanaji Jadhav, is a builder in Pune, known for getting slumdwellers good deals for their land and constructing buildings on them. "The new generation is still tuned into history and culture, at least in Maharashtra."

Jaywantrao Mohite is a retired professional, one of the few men in his family who didn't join the army. His ancestor Hambirrao Mohite was the commander-in-chief of Shivaji's army after his death in 1680. In keeping with the family tradition, two of Jaywantrao's cousins won the Victoria Cross in World War II. He echoes Chavan's words, "History of figures like Hambirrao and others who fought with Shivaji should be known." He proudly preserves old ancestral artefacts, including a tiger claw and a steel scorpion which were used as weapons. Hambirrao's daughter was married to Shivaji's younger son Raja Ram.

Pride is discernible on the faces of Kaustubh Deshpande and Sandip Potnis, descendants of Shivaji's Kayastha commanders Baji Prabhu Deshpande and Murar Baji Baji. Baji Prabhu held off Bijapur general Siddi Jauda's forces for seven hours at the Pawakind mountain pass near Kolhapur, letting Shivaji escape. Baji Prabhu was wounded 47 times in the battle. A computer professional, Kaustubh's efforts to build a monument in his ancestral village Shind as homage to his ancestor have gone in vain. "It is unfortunate that there is an utter lack of respect in certain quarters for such a war hero," he says about the government's apathy.

Potnis, a farmer near Pune, is proud of his ancestry. "If Indians are to give a befitting reply to the hostile designs of China and Pakistan, the saga of warriors like Murar Baji must be spread to inspire bravery and patriotism in the new generation," he says. Padmasenraje Dabhade and his son Satyashil Dabhade agree. "We don't understand why the exploits of such great figures don't figure uniformly across the country in history books in schools," they say. Both are descendants of the general Khanderao Dabhade who played a key role in extending Maratha power north of the Narmada during the reign of Shivaji's grandson Sahu. The Dadhaves live in their Pune flat, which is lined with some of the oldest documents of their family. One of their women ancestors Umabhai Dabhade, the daughter-in-law of

